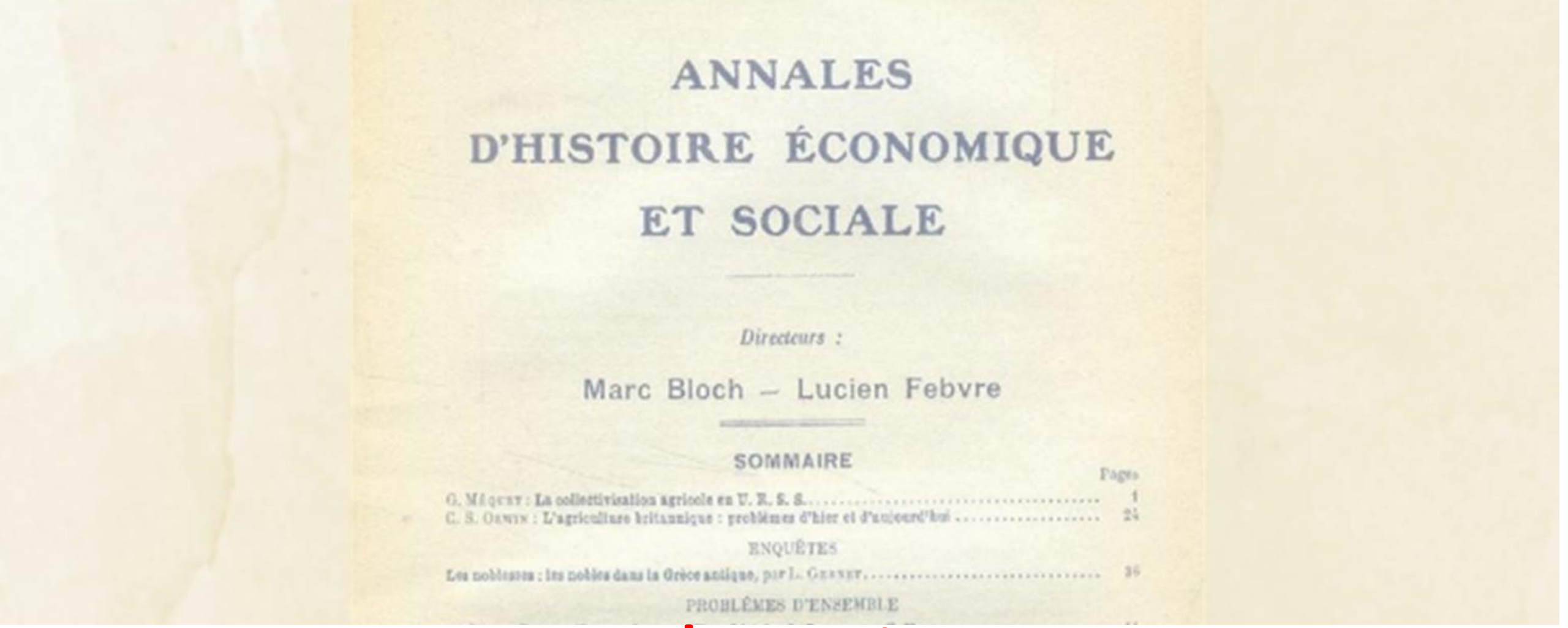

ANNALES
D'HISTOIRE ÉCONOMIQUE
ET SOCIALE

Directeurs :

Marc Bloch — Lucien Febvre

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PROBLÈMES D'ENSEMBLE

Annales History

- Aniket Alam
- Introduction to History HS3.201
- Monsoon 2026

What do historians do?

- Two broad approaches to studying History: Inductive and Deductive.
- All theories and methods of History base themselves on these two
- Rankean and Annales Historians use the Inductive Method
- Marxist, Structuralist and Post-Structuralist theories use Deductive

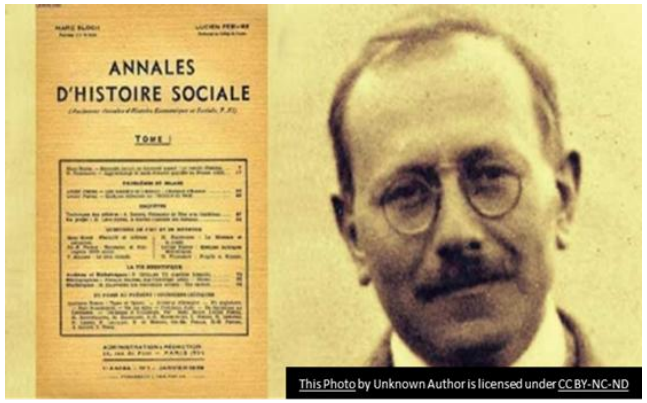
SOME COMMONALITIES

- The importance of the Fact
- How is it verified and corroborated,
- What can it tell us and what it cannot
- The play between fact and interpretation.
- Two Visions of History: Progress v/s Decline.

Inductive Method

- From facts to generalisations to theory
- No certainty, only degrees of
  - Probability
  - Possibility
- No *a-priori* assumptions
  - Moves from observable facts to general condition
- Cause and effect are not pre-determined
- Conformation bias, available information bias
  - Difficulty of explanation





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Foundations

- Rankean, Positivist History is insufficient
  - Past is not only about political affairs
  - Archives not just old documents and texts
- Inductive method
  - History has to be based on facts
  - But these should cover all aspects of life
- Gave the agenda of Total History

- Based on two methodological foundations
  1. Quantitative History
  2. Comparative History

- *Annales d'histoire économique et sociale*
  - Annales of Economic and Social History (1929)
- Marc Bloch and Lucien Febvre

Total History

- History has to study all aspects of the past
  - How people lived and in what shelters…
  - What they grew and collected…
  - What food they ate…
  - What clothes they wore…
  - How they produced and traded….
  - What social hierarchies were there; who did what and why…
  - Art, Culture, Ways of Life, Beliefs …
  - The non-human world : how it influenced the human world and how humans changed it

- "relegated the sensational to the sidelines"
- *"l'histoire tout court"*: study all aspects of a historical question

New Sources

- Go beyond official documents of state and church
- Trade statistics
- Agriculture statistics
- Geography markers and natural remains
- Oral and Visual records

ANYTHING CAN BE A SOURCE OF HISTORICAL EVIDENCE:

A FACT











New Agendas

- The importance of Regions in the study of history
  - Defines the context for historical trends and processes
  - Gives meaning to the events, facts
- Total History led to focus on sub-regions, locality, village
  - Regions also can be larger or different than empire!
- Micro-history
  - Looks intensively at a small unit of space and time
  - Asks large questions (because linked to the region)
- Smaller building blocks build the larger picture
- Shift study from the big to the small and the imperceptible

THE ANCIENT MEDITERRANEAN
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Quantitative History

INDUCTIVE METHOD

- Historian needs to collect all the evidence
  - Corroborate it, clean it, collate it, classify it
- Find patterns
  - Beyond the immediate and visible
- Long periods of time
  - Decades or even centuries
- Quantify historical events and processes
  - Statistical tools to study historical data
- History as a Social Science

Comparative History

- Historical phenomenon can be understood only by comparison to other historical phenomenon
- Identify both common and unique
- Evaluate what is important and what is not
- All historical enquiry has to be comparative, if it has to tell us something useful
- Thus, *Annales* laid the foundations for a global history with the inductive method

IMPORTANCE OF GEOGRAPHY

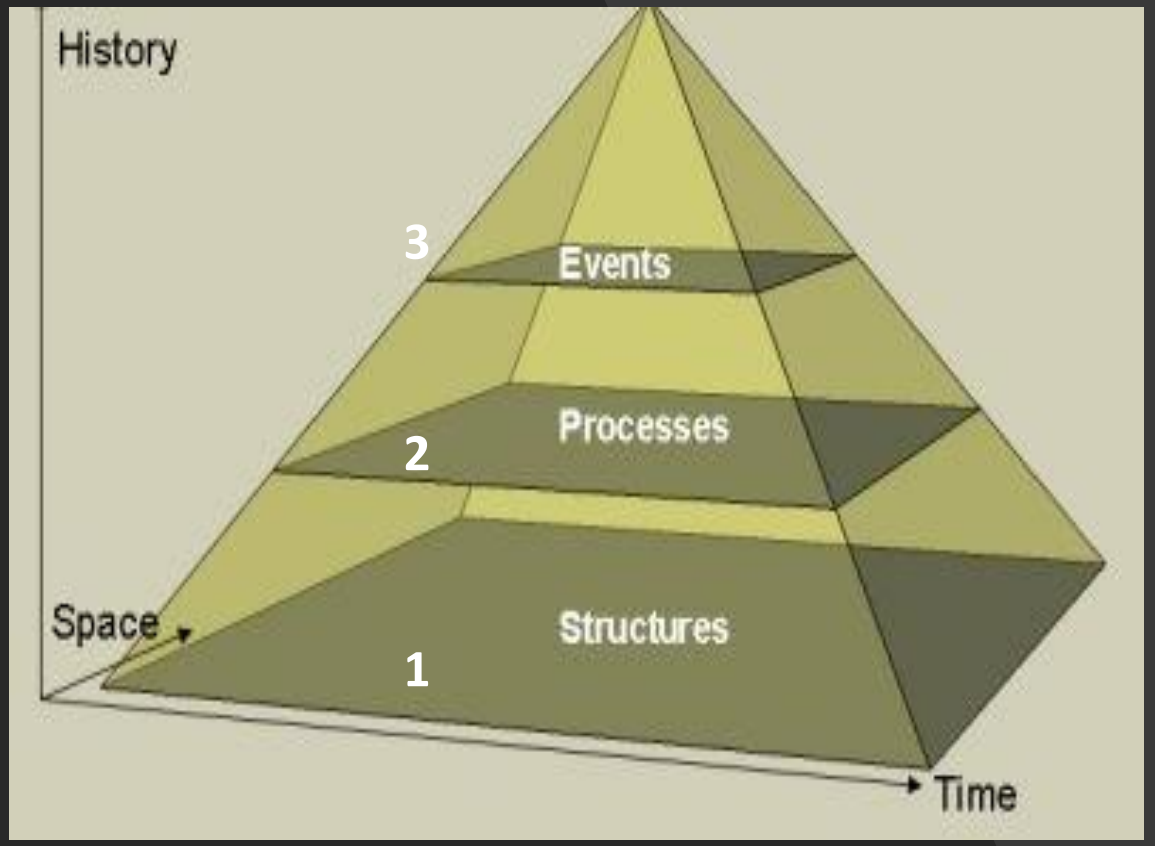
- Human actions take place in a natural setting: geography
- Rivers, Mountains, Snow, Rain, Forests, Meadows
  - **Limiting conditions**; **Enabling conditions** to what humans can do
  - The Mediterranean; The Alps
- Climate
- Natural Limits and Human Society
- Frontiers and States
- Human interaction with their geography makes for historical regions
  - Historical regions are the proper area of study

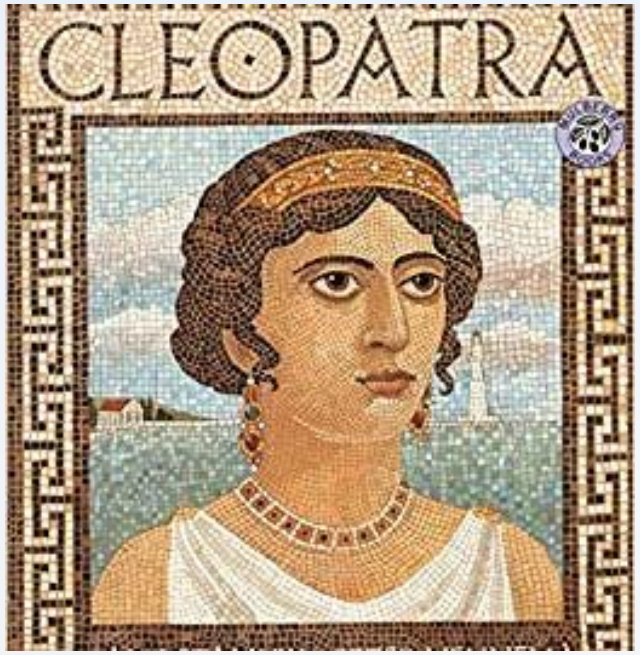
Three Rhythms of Time

- Fernand Braudel
- Historical time was ideally viewed as the amalgamation of three distinct rhythms
  - Time of Structure; or Geographical Time
  - Time of Conjuncture; or Social-Economic Time
  - Time of Events; or Political Time

1. First historian has to establish geographical time: base/foundation
2. On the basis of geographical time, historians need to establish social-economic trends
3. Only after this can historians study events, or political history

- Without 1 and 2 having been established, 3 makes no sense
- The structural and conjunctural time rhythms are the "*longue durée*"







Longue Durée

- Long duration
  - Historical periods which stretch over centuries; often millennia
- Changes in the *longue durée* are often imperceptible but also very stable
  - Historians have neglected it
  - Historical methods do not encourage studying it
- Central to understand and explain the past
- Without a proper description of the longue durée there can be no good historical account

Histoire Des Mentalités

- Mental Architecture
  - How time, space, emotions, feelings, attitudes are organized inside our minds
- World View, *Weltanschauung*
- How we experience our lives, actions, events, how we understand them, and explain them to ourselves
  - Authority, Human Will, Love, Death, Social Structure, Nature…
- Provides the categories through which we can see the world
  - Structures everything Human
- Often exists over long stretches of time: *longue durée*

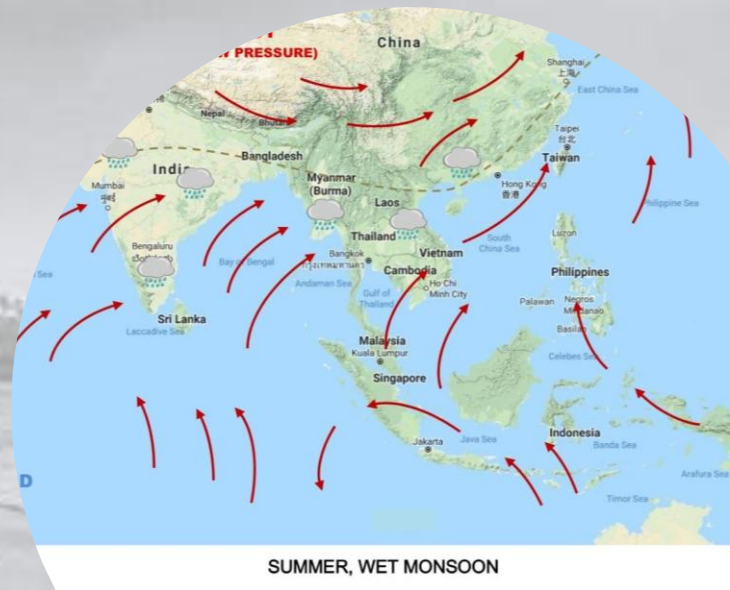
Caste

- Emergence of Varna
- Advent of Jati
- Dharma-sastras established a “caste system” as social law of divine origin
- Endogamous social groups arranged hierarchically; linked to labour division, asset control and social status
- Classic longue durée
  - Survived one and a half millennium
- Both conjuncture and *mentalités*
- Determines how society is organized, economy works, and also how we perceive social ties and economic activities

Monsoon



- 5 to 20 million years old
  - Pre-Human condition of climate
  - Effect on topography; on flora and fauna
- Foundation of Indian calendars
  - Lunar, Luni-Solar: but the influence of the monsoon cannot be missed
- Under-grids Indian economy, political power, social systems
  - Has not changed from hunter-gatherer, pastoral, agricultural, mercantile, to industrial society
- How do we understand the role of monsoons in Indian history?
  - The baap of longue durée



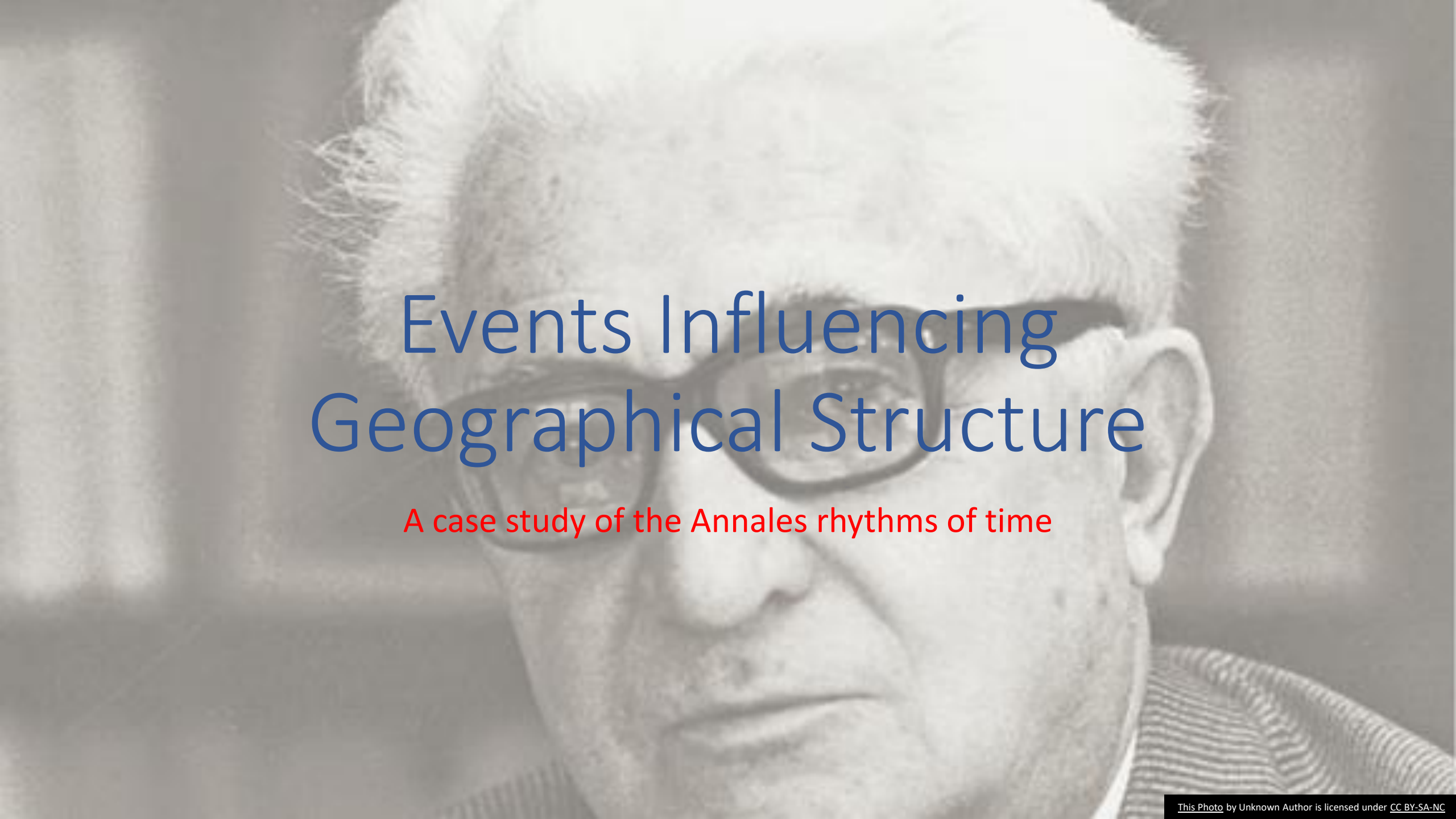
SUMMER, WET MONSOON

Forests

- Thick forests of the Ganges plains
  - Think Sundarbans; Jim-Corbett National Park
- Two and a half millennium long process of de-forestation
  - From Delhi to Dhaka
- Iron and Fire used extensively
- Indo-Gangetic Forests
  - Linked to the climate
  - Provided tools; raw materials
  - Created its “Civilisation”
- Historical importance ended with industrial capitalism
  - Commodity







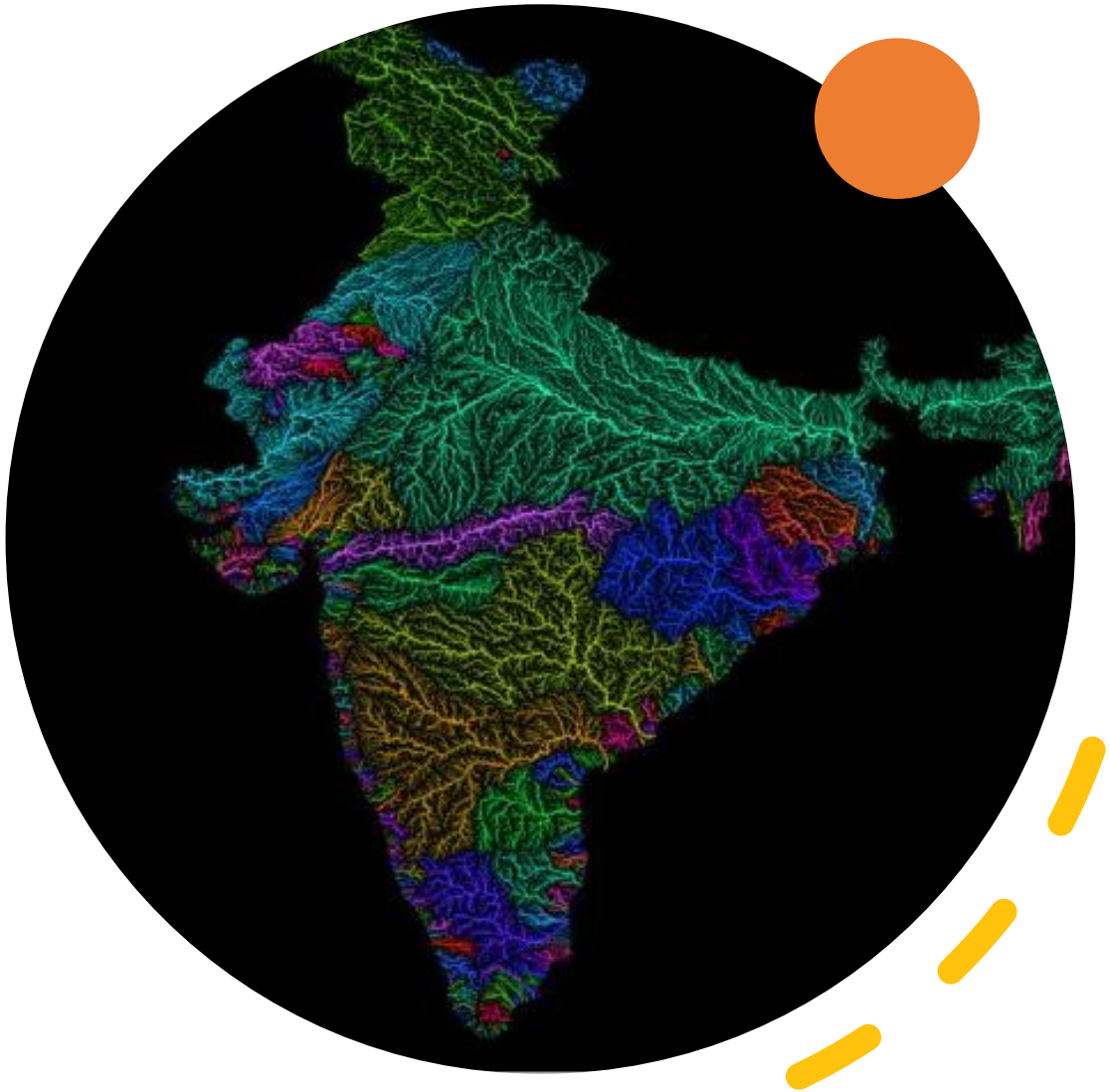
Events Influencing Geographical Structure

A case study of the Annales rhythms of time

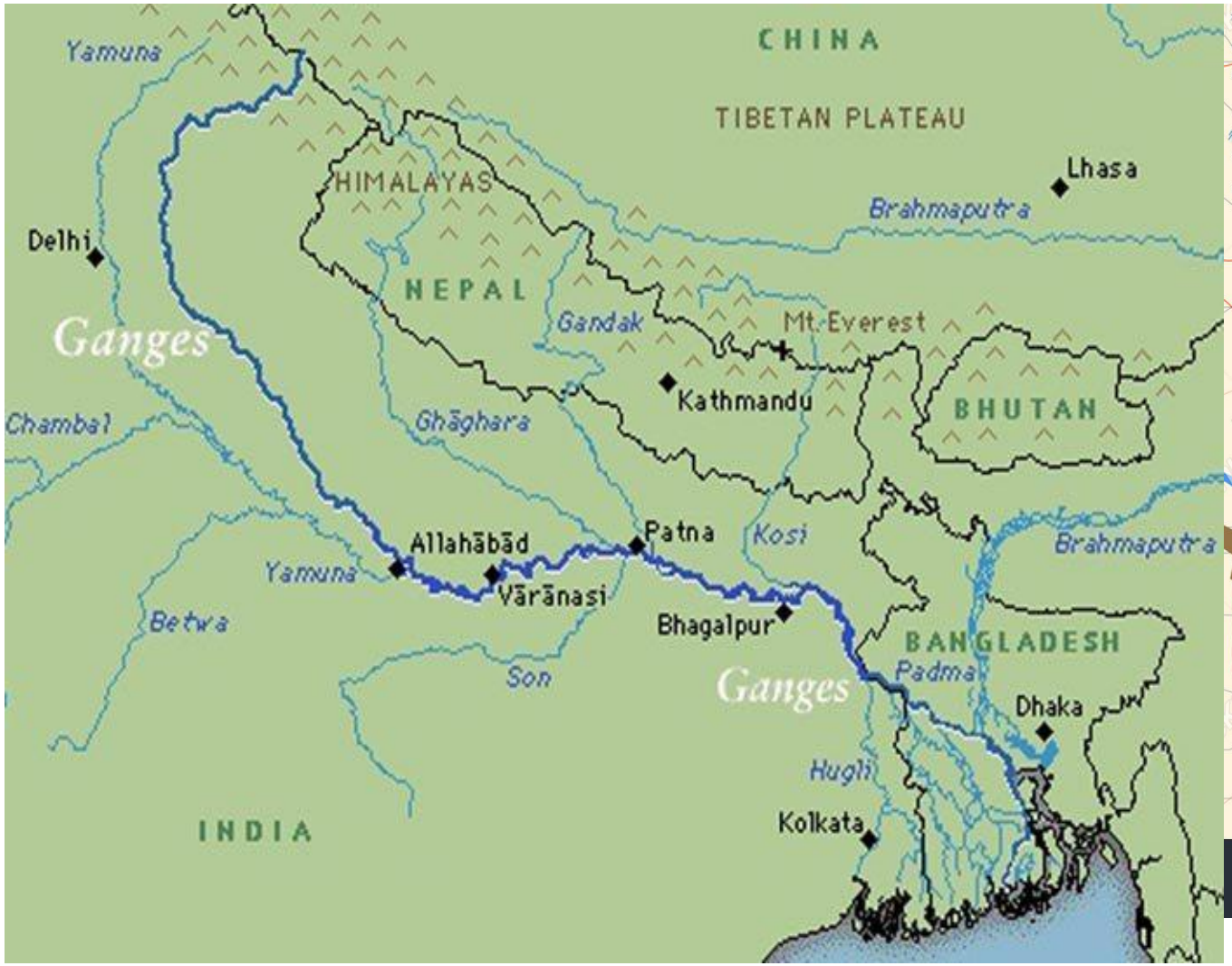
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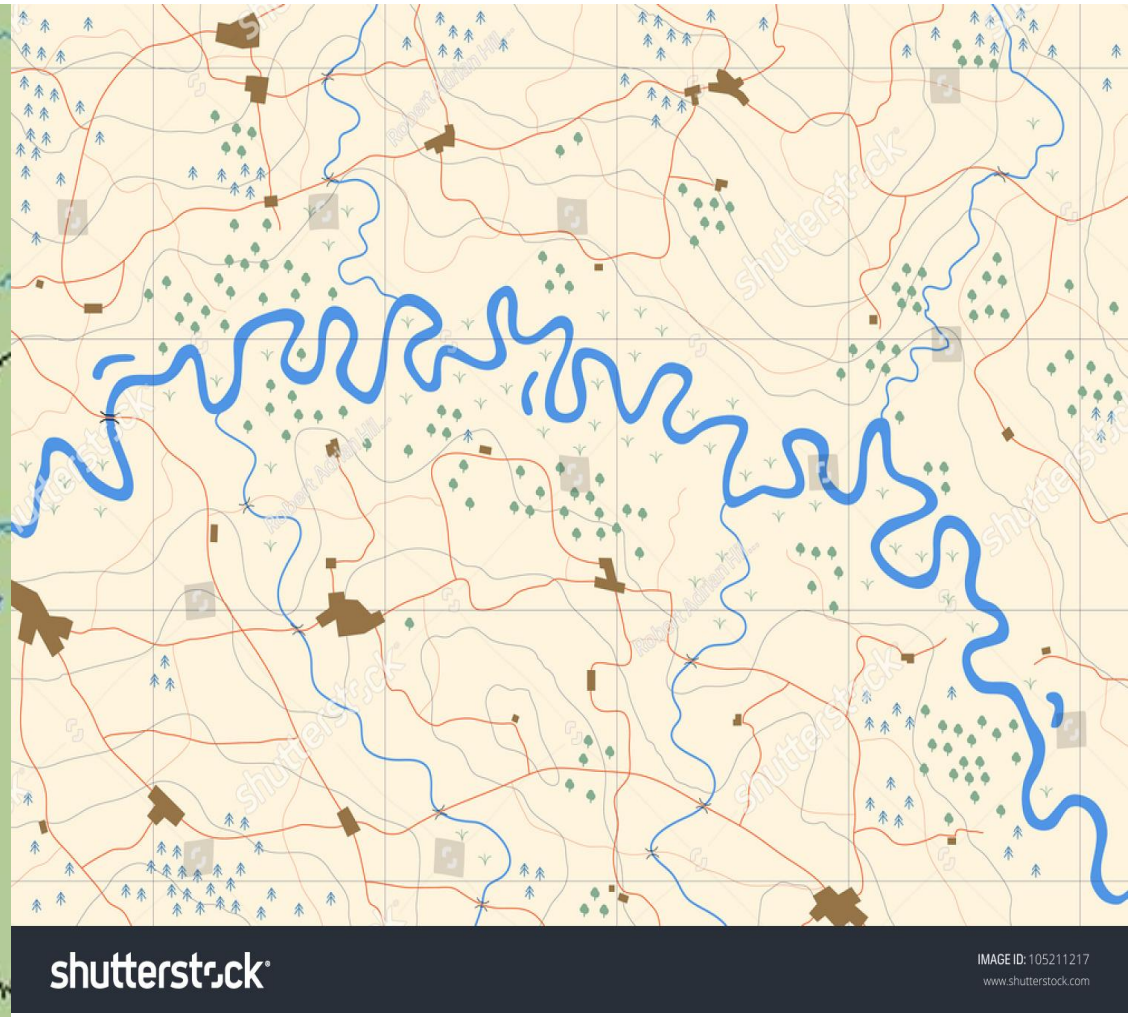
Gangetic Rivers & Plains

- Rivers come down from the Himalayas
- And the central Indian mountains
- Carry silt and plant matter
- Seasonal load of water varies
- Gangetic plain is flat land composed of silt accumulated over hundreds of millennia
- Rivers meander and change course frequently
- Similar story of the Brahmaputra, Mahanadi, deltaic Godavari and Krishna…



Meandering River, Changing Course





Society and Economy

- The conjuncture adjusted to this structure
- Habitation (village, town) had a corporate, community identity and moved with the river
  - Sometime from one bank to the other; sometime up and down stream
- Social organization remained the same
- Economic relations within and without the habitation remained the same
- State dealt with the habitation for taxes and levies
- …Irrespective of actual map location

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A New Conjuncture

- Colonialism: British Rule
- Came with new technology, new ideas of society and economy
- Habitation is geotagged and is now exact place on the map
- Helped geo-fix habitation with new map technology
- Habitation is empty space irrespective of people who live there
  - If the entire population of a town or village is replaced in two generations, that does not mean the town / village has changed
- How does one protect this geo-fixed habitation from the meandering river?
  - New technology: Embankments

Geo-Fixing the River

- The river's course is fixed on the map
- A change of river's course is a catastrophe
  - Towns and rivers flood
  - Agriculture fields are destroyed
  - Revenue is lost
- To keep habitations, society and economy fixed and predictable
  - Rivers have to be fixed and predictable
- Rivers have to remain within the "natural" course which has been marked on the map
- This is done by building embankments

Embankments

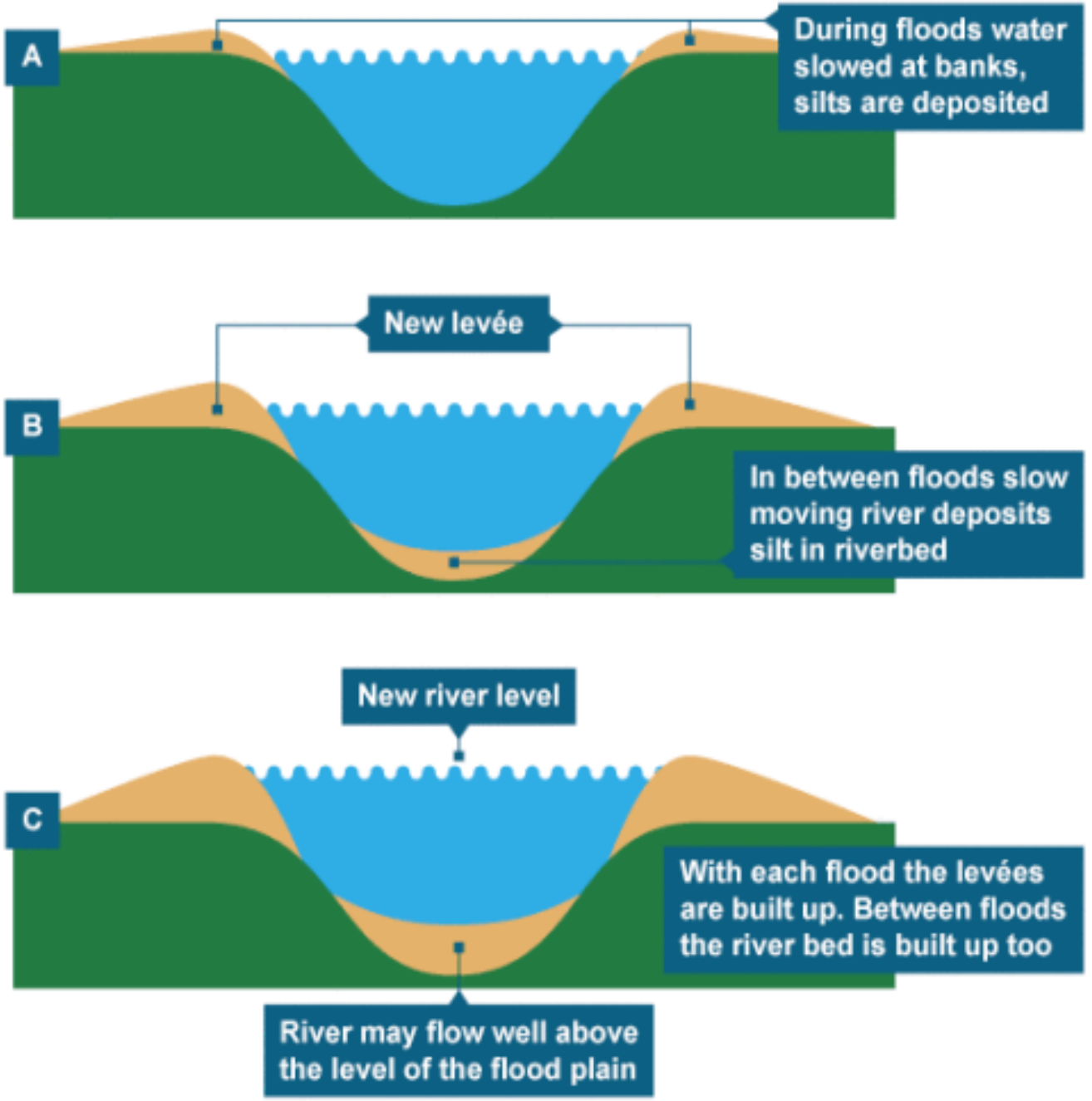
- Walls on both sides of the river
- Keep flood waters inside the river
- Prevent flooding
- Keep villages and cities dry during flood season and thus allow them to remain geo-fixed



The Problem

- Rivers cannot spread their silt across the flood plains
- The silt settles into the bottom of the riverbed
- Over time (a few decades) the riverbed rises, and…
- The river again breaches the embankment
- So the embankments have to be made higher and longer
- This process goes on till the riverbed is now higher than the flood plain!

Riverbed Higher than Flood Plain





Result of Embankments

Increased and heavier floods


TOI





Event Changes Structure

- Embankments came up within less than a century
  - Two three decades, half a century
  - Kosi river embankments started in the 1960s and finished by the late 1990s
- Classic Time-of-events
  - Pushed by political events: elections and vote catching mechanism
  - Immediate relief from the next flood
- Once built they are irreversible
  - Change the course of the river
  - Fix the river to a given geographical course
- Within a few decades change hundreds of thousands of years of geographical flow
  - Start a new geographical time?



Other Examples??

- How would an Annales historian see this?
- A great, if tragic, example of how an understanding of history can help us understand the present
- But still historians remain helpless to change it!!
- What other examples can we think of where events in Political Time make radical changes to the structures of Geographical Time?